



The Board Changed, the Question Didn't

A Pre/Post Patron Survey of Lifeguard Queries About Lane Rotation Before and After a Public Pool Installed a Digital Display

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Motivation

A digital lane-rotation display promises an at-a-glance answer to which lane clears next. Installing the screen is one thing; getting lap swimmers to trust it over a person is another. Does the board replace the question, or just add a second place to ignore?

What we set out to test

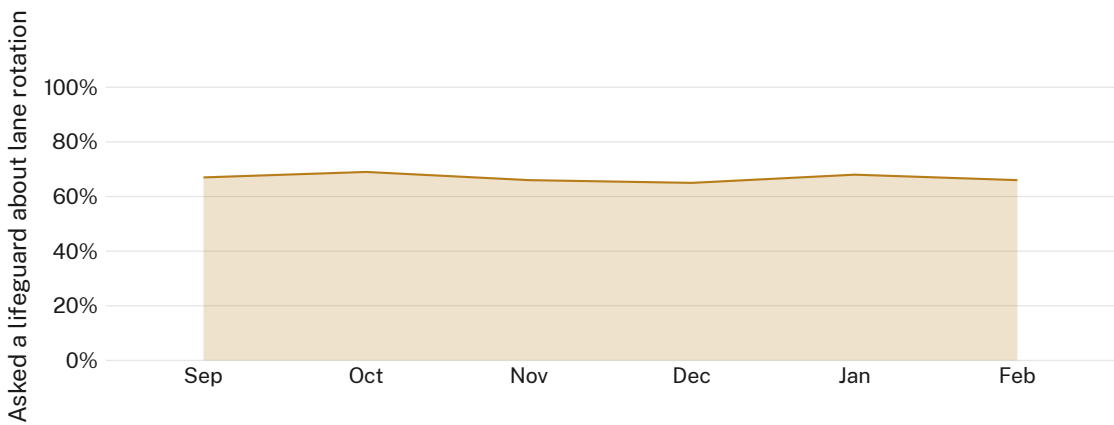
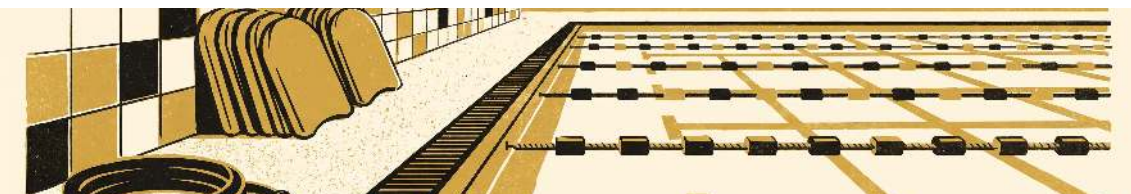
- Whether a digital lane-rotation display reduces how often lap swimmers ask a lifeguard about lane rotation
- Whether display legibility (glare, mounting height, sightline) moderates any change in asking rate
- Whether a notice period ahead of installation shifts patron expectations before the board goes live

Study design

- $n = 412$ lap swimmers · exit-intercept survey · 3 public pools · 6 months (3 pre-, 3 post-installation)
- self-reported lifeguard queries per session, cross-checked against lifeguard shift logs
- lifeguard rostering and shift counts held constant across the study window

Results & analysis

The self-reported asking rate holds at 68% pre-installation and 66% post-installation, a gap the model attributes to sampling noise rather than the display. Legibility complaints peak in the first fortnight, then flatten alongside everything else.



Monthly asking rate holds inside a 5-point band across the December 2025 installation date, never dropping below 65%.

Discussion & conclusions

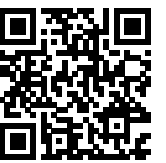
A board on the wall changes what information is available, not what swimmers do with it. Reliance on the lifeguard tracks trust in a person, not the absence of a sign. Next: test whether training lifeguards to point at the display, rather than answer, moves the rate at all.

Selected references

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2. Parasuraman, R., & Riley, V. (1997). Humans and automation: Use, misuse, disuse, abuse. *Human Factors*, 39(2), 230–253. doi:10.1518/001872097778543886
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Thanks to the deck staff of the three instrumented pools; no patron identifying information retained.

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“Same question, new board bolted to the wall.”

68% of patrons still ask a lifeguard at 3-month follow-up, unchanged from the pre-installation rate.